

Chapter 22 - Chrysanthemums

This face had appeared before her and stayed for a very long time, only back then she wasn't called Man'er, but Du Baishuang¹.

Heavenly Mountain's treasure, the mountain's cloud crane, Du Baishuang.

"Yiyi, what are you standing there for!" Liu Wenzhu, who was entangled in combat with the man nearby, called out urgently. Only then did Ning Fuyi break free from her memories, pushing the young girl behind her with one hand while summoning immortal power with both hands to block the nine fox tails coming her way.

Those tails looked fluffy and soft, but when touched, they were like barbed iron hammers, hitting Ning Fuyi until her throat tasted of blood. She barely managed to withstand one strike when the nine tails changed position, seemingly determined not to stop until they hammered her to death.

"Here they come again!" Ning Fuyi cursed loudly, pulling the young girl as they retreated repeatedly. In her desperation, she dodged toward Chu Qingqiu.

"Divine Venerable, save me!" she shamelessly shouted.

As soon as her words fell, Chu Qingqiu was already standing in front of her. Several white silks shot out like white snakes, each one wrapping around the woman, blocking her chaotic tails while also sending her flying against the wall with a heavy thud.

The woman rolled to the ground, blood spattering her clothes.

"You cannot defeat this venerable." Chu Qingqiu stood in place, letting the white silks fall softly like falling snow. She had already returned to her female appearance, her features cold and clear.

"Surrender now."

"Bah! You two-faced liar!" Seeing her true appearance, the woman immediately realized she had been deceived and began cursing viciously. But after only a few curses, white silk wrapped around her mouth.

"And you." As soon as Chu Qingqiu finished speaking, the white silks rose again, binding the man who was fighting with Liu Wenzhu and throwing him against the wall in the same manner. Another muffled groan, and blood spurted out a second time.

The speed was so fast that Ning Fuyi couldn't help but want to applaud. These two people seemed like ants in Chu Qingqiu's eyes - she held White Bone² in her hand throughout and barely moved.

"Speak. Why did you kidnap these people?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

The man didn't answer, spitting on the ground instead.

"Why waste words on them?" Ning Fuyi couldn't stand it anymore. She immediately stepped forward, grabbed the man's chin to lift his face, and gave him a series of slaps, hitting him until his face and head were red and blood dripped from both nostrils.

"Huo Lang!" Seeing the man being beaten, the woman suddenly stood up and blocked in front of him, taking Ning Fuyi's punch directly. Ning Fuyi quickly stopped, raising an eyebrow at the woman standing in front of the man.

She had thought they were accomplices, but it turned out to be deep conjugal love. She sneered.

"If you won't speak, someone else will." Ning Fuyi supported herself on her knee as she stood up, waving her hand to send several streams of immortal power to break the Dark Iron³ cage locks.

Most of the imprisoned people were covered in wounds, some even with broken legs, lying on the ground crying and wailing. Among them were men, women, young and old. Only a few who seemed newly captured were relatively healthy, carefully pushing open the cage doors but not daring to come forward.

She hadn't had time to look closely before, but now seeing such misery made one unable to bear looking further.

"Immortal masters, please seek justice for us!" Suddenly a heartbreaking cry rang out. A young man finally rushed forward, fell to his knees, and was about to bang his forehead heavily on the ground when Liu Wenzhu quickly caught him, tears flowing from her red eyes.

"This is the renowned Divine Venerable Chu Ling⁴. Whatever happened, you can tell her everything." Liu Wenzhu said gently.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling." The man took a deep breath, his eyes bloodshot as he looked at the man with tears streaming down his face. "This humble one was originally an ordinary medicinal herb in Tongchuan. I cultivated human form after gathering the spiritual energy of heaven and earth. But shortly after taking shape, I was captured and brought here. Besides me, all the other Spirit Clan members here were hunted and brought by them. Locked in this place without seeing daylight, almost daily people would come to select victims. Those chosen would be taken away and devoured alive!"

"Devoured alive?" Liu Wenzhu was shocked and stood frozen. Though she had heard of such evil acts, witnessing such bloody scenes firsthand still gave her quite a shock.

Though they were legendarily Spirit Clan members, they all appeared human. How could anyone bear to harm them?

"These two are extremely cruel. If they capture beautiful women, they bewitch their minds and place them in this Ruyan Tower as a cover. On the surface it's a pleasure house, but in reality they're secretly trafficking people. I don't know how many of our clan have died at their hands. Please, Divine Venerable, save us from this fire and water!" The man wept bitterly, prostrating himself on the ground.

Chu Qingqiu listened to his account, already gripping White Bone tightly in her hand, her thin lips pressed together, her eyes full of anger.

The next moment, that white jade staff suddenly extended, pointing directly at the man's throat. The ice-cold staff surface actually burst into white flames, light filling the entire cellar. But the woman again blocked in front of the man, looking ready to die for him. Chu Qingqiu could no longer bear it and loosened the white silk from her mouth, shouting sternly: "You're clearly also from the fox clan, yet for one man you capture your own kind. What kind of stone heart do you have!"

"Stone heart?" The woman's clothes were disheveled and her hair was a mess, yet she was even more breathtakingly beautiful. The flower petals in her eyes glowed faintly. "This is love."

"From the moment he picked that Emperor's Daughter Flower⁵ and handed it to me, I was deeply rooted in love for him. He said that once he cultivates to immortality, he would retreat with me to Heavenly Mountain. This is the love of being together for a lifetime as a couple. What do clansmen matter? How could you people who constantly speak of righteousness and propriety understand!"

The cellar fell silent for a moment, with only the occasional sobbing of Spirit Clan members.

"Madwoman." Chu Qingqiu looked at her for a while and frowned.

Even Ning Fuyi found these words incomprehensible. She looked at the man the woman was protecting and clicked her tongue: "He's so ugly, and you fell deeply in love just because he gave you a chrysanthemum? If I gave you a room full of white chrysanthemums, wouldn't you love me to death?"

"Shut up!" the woman said with disgust.

Ning Fuyi closed her mouth.

"Oh no, I forgot - you're different." The woman suddenly turned her gaze to Chu Qingqiu, her red lips curving as she slowly stood up. "You have someone hidden in your heart too, and you've also done things that betray propriety."

Chu Qingqiu's nails almost dug into her palm. Her pair of peach blossom eyes looked at the woman coldly, the red at the corners of her eyes becoming more obvious.

Liu Wenzhu and Ning Fuyi exchanged glances, both seeing surprise in each other's eyes. Even for Ning Fuyi, Chu Qingqiu seemed extremely upright - what could she have done that betrayed propriety?

"You fell in love with someone you shouldn't have..." The woman's voice became seductive, like a whisper, as if bewitching hearts and souls. She stared intently at Chu Qingqiu and walked toward her.

While the two were struggling over something there, Ning Fuyi had long grown impatient. She looked around on the ground, picked up a palm-sized stone, weighed it, and threw it straight at the woman's forehead. The woman cried out, and a bruise appeared on her fair forehead.

The earlier heart-captivating feeling instantly disappeared. Chu Qingqiu startled, then became even more furious. The white jade staff spun a half-circle in the air and struck the woman back to her original position with one blow. How could the woman's mortal body withstand Chu Qingqiu's strike? Her eyes immediately rolled back and she tumbled like a broken rag to the man's feet.

Ning Fuyi was startled by this sudden action. She had never seen Chu Qingqiu with such great fury, nor had she ever seen her display killing intent in front of her. But the current Chu Qingqiu seemed like a different person - though dressed in flowing white robes, she was as fierce as a killing god, able to kill with one strike.

The white jade staff blazing with white fire spun in the air, then aimed straight down at the man's skull. The man's lower body was bound and he couldn't dodge. At the critical moment, he actually reached out to grab the woman and use her to block the strike.

"Damn it." Ning Fuyi cursed loudly. Chu Qingqiu's eyes became even colder. The moment the white jade staff fell, dozens of white silks rose from the ground, their soft edges turning into sharp blades. In the blink of an eye, they pierced through the man's heart.

The man immediately stared with wide eyes and instantly went limp. Both bodies fell together, looking from afar as if they were embracing each other.

The others hadn't reacted yet, standing stunned for a while before relaxing. Those kidnapped Spirit Clan members cried together, while Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu stood together, unable to describe their feelings.

"How can there be such foolish people?" Liu Wenzhu clenched her fists. "Love should be protection, not a reason to harm others."

"Hatred is." Ning Fuyi said flatly. She looked at Chu Qingqiu's back - that figure was slender, upright, and lonely.

"I've never seen the Divine Venerable harm anyone before. I thought she never killed." Liu Wenzhu was somewhat frightened.

Ning Fuyi said nothing.

What followed was quite straightforward. Rong Jin happened to contact Elder Yuanming, who came with people to take the imprisoned and bewitched Spirit Clan members to safety for treatment. This matter was of great importance, and all Six Great Sects sent envoys to Furong Town to thoroughly investigate the trafficking of Spirit Clan members - but that's a story for later.

"Yiyi, Man'er has fainted. Should we have Elder Yuanming take her with the other Spirit Clan members, or bring her back to see that aunt?" Liu Wenzhu held the young girl horizontally in both arms, looking troubled. "After all, that's her mother..."

"Mother?" Ning Fuyi shook her head. "How could a mortal give birth to a Spirit Clan child? Besides, that dog couple wouldn't have had the audacity to snatch people in broad daylight."

Hearing this, Liu Wenzhu's eyes widened in shock: "You mean..."

"That woman was also involved in capturing Spirit Clan members. She probably planned to sell them to Ruyan Tower, but when they couldn't agree on a price, she broke the pot and pretended to be her mother, wanting us to help her reclaim her prey." Ning Fuyi's eyes were somewhat cold.

"So that's how it was!" Liu Wenzhu angrily raised her eyebrows. "I'll notify Senior Brother Rong Jin immediately - we mustn't let that swindler escape!"

"As for Man'er, she's still so young. I'll take her back first, and we'll decide what to do when she wakes up." Liu Wenzhu said.

Ning Fuyi was just thinking of properly determining whether Man'er was really Du Baishuang. This arrangement suited her perfectly, so she didn't object and followed Liu Wenzhu up the stairs, returning to the gradually softening sunlight outside.

The sun was setting in the west but hadn't yet fallen, making the distant mountains look as if they were dusted with gold powder. Just as Ning Fuyi was about to breathe some fresh air, Liu Wenzhu frowned and said: "Yiyi, look."

She looked in the direction Liu Wenzhu was pointing and was momentarily stunned. She saw Chu Qingqiu walking alone ahead, her robe hem hanging lonely on the ground, her shoulders straight, with a few fallen leaves on them.

For some reason, this scene looked particularly desolate.

"Yiyi, the Divine Venerable seems unhappy." Liu Wenzhu was observant. She bumped Ning Fuyi with her shoulder and said softly: "You go talk to her and cheer her up."

"I don't want to." Ning Fuyi blurted out. Cheer up Chu Qingqiu? Unless she had been kicked in the head by a donkey.

"Come on, go. I've never seen the Divine Venerable with such an expression." Liu Wenzhu simply started acting spoiled. How could Ning Fuyi resist? After being bumped twice, she reluctantly agreed.

"I'm leaving then, you go, you go." Having gotten her way, Liu Wenzhu smiled and left with Man'er in her arms, leaving only Ning Fuyi standing alone on the crowded street, watching Chu Qingqiu walking farther and farther away.

Damn it, she had never comforted anyone before, especially someone like Chu Qingqiu who was cold-hearted and impervious to reason.

But Liu Wenzhu's request was hard to refuse.

She looked around. The surroundings were all shops selling spiritual instruments and medicines, with nothing particularly interesting. However, there seemed to be a flower shop not far away with white and yellow flowers that looked quite nice.

So she ran over quickly and threw a water jade⁶ to the shopkeeper: "Shopkeeper, give me a bouquet of flowers."

"Certainly! Would you like this kind of wreath or that kind of wreath?" the shopkeeper asked with a smile.

"What wreaths? Just a bouquet of flowers." Ning Fuyi looked carefully and frowned. "Why are they all chrysanthemums?"

"This small shop only has chrysanthemums." The shopkeeper smiled awkwardly.

"Fine, fine, I'll take the white ones." Seeing that Chu Qingqiu's figure was about to disappear, she was too lazy to care about anything else. She grabbed a bouquet and ran toward Chu Qingqiu.

The evening breeze blew coolly. She had already returned to her female form, with a fair complexion and flying hair. Slightly out of breath, she stopped in front of the distracted Chu Qingqiu.

Her phoenix eyes widened, her dark pupils reflecting Chu Qingqiu's figure. Crystal sweat beaded on her forehead as she smiled and held up a large bouquet of snow-white flowers.

"Divine Venerable, these are for you."

Author's Notes:

Chu Qingqiu: Darling, please clarify first - are you giving them to me, or sending me away⁷?

Footnotes:

1. **Du Baishuang (杜白双)** - A character name meaning "Du White Frost"
 2. **White Bone (白骨)** - Chu Qingqiu's weapon that can transform between a flute and staff
 3. **Dark Iron (玄铁)** - A mystical metal known for its strength
 4. **Chu Ling (褚凌)** - Chu Qingqiu's formal title as Divine Venerable
 5. **Emperor's Daughter Flower (帝女花)** - A type of chrysanthemum with cultural significance
 6. **Water jade (水玉)** - A type of currency in the cultivation world
 7. **Author's note reference** - In Chinese, giving white chrysanthemums traditionally has funeral/mourning connotations, hence Chu Qingqiu's hypothetical confusion about whether the flowers are a gift or a veiled threat
-

Author's Notes: This chapter reveals the shocking truth that the rescued girl Man'er is actually Du Baishuang, someone from Ning Fuyi's past. The violent resolution of the trafficking ring shows a rare display of Chu Qingqiu's killing intent, while the ending sets up a tender moment between the main characters with the symbolic offering of chrysanthemums.